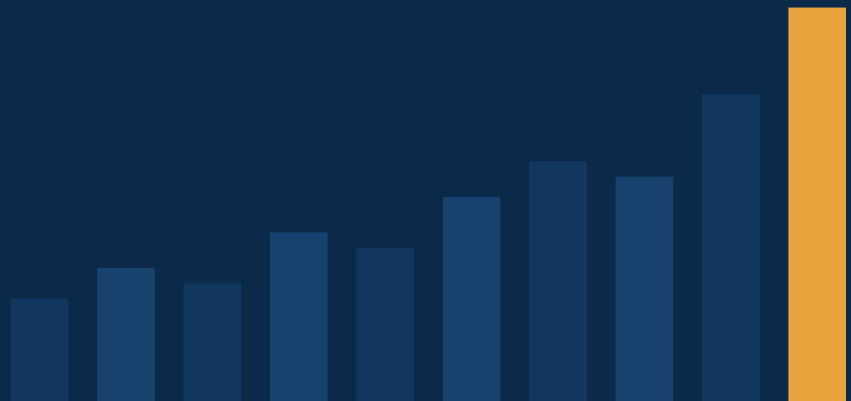


LAB GUIDE

PARTICIPANT

Participant Lab Guide

Power BI Storytelling and Report Design for Business Impact



Version 1.0, October 2026

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Before you start

What you will build today

By 3:15 this afternoon you will have turned a crowded report page into a short, guided story with three levels: a summary that states the headline, a diagnostic page that explains it, and a detail page that tells someone what to do on Monday.

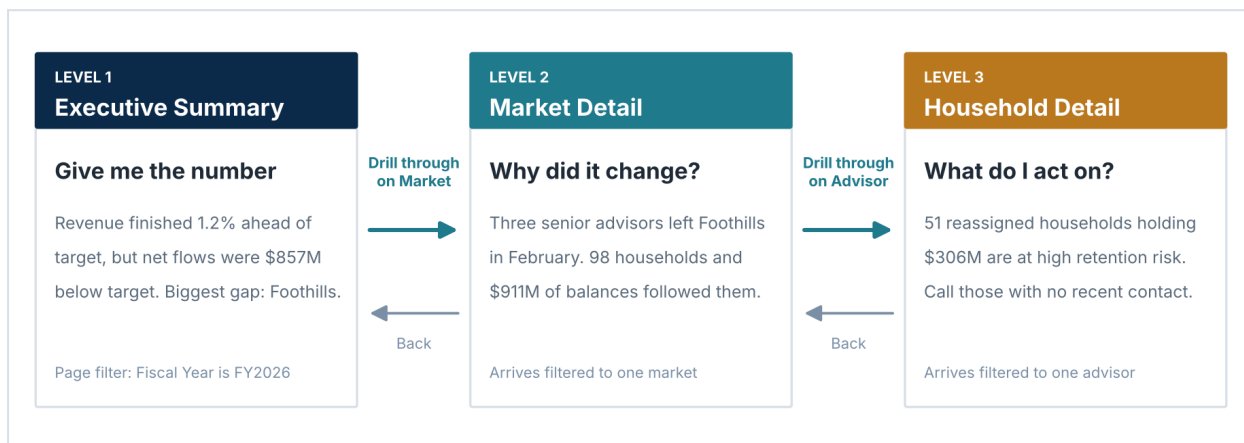


Figure 1. The journey you will build: three levels, connected by drillthrough

The hands-on work is spread across the day. Each lab follows the slides, so you always know where you are.

Lab	When	Slide	What you do
Lab 1 Visual-selection challenge and page redesign	Module 2, about 11:30	32	Replace poorly chosen visuals, sketch a cleaner executive page, start the build
Follow-along Edit interactions	Module 3, about 1:10	36	Decide how one visual affects the others
Lab 2 A two-level referral journey	Module 3, about 1:45	47	Design a summary-to-detail path and wire it with drillthrough
Lab 3 Guided build and refinement	Module 4, 2:00 to 3:15	48 to 58	Build the executive view, compare visuals, add drillthrough, tune, theme, publish, and run a trust check

The scenario

You are an analyst on the Wealth Data and Analytics team at **Ridgemere Wealth Management**. Ridgemere's fiscal year runs from 1 November to 31 October. Fiscal 2026 closed a few days ago, and the year-end review is next week.

Ridgemere is fictional. Every advisor, client, market, and number was invented for this course. Nothing here is BMO data.

The people you are designing for:

Person	Role	What they need from a report
Catherine Bouchard	Head of Wealth Distribution	The number, fast. She reads on a tablet before the executive committee.
Daniel Okafor	Regional Vice President, Mountain	An explanation of his region's result and where to spend his time.
Priya Raman	Market Leader, Foothills	Household-level detail she can act on. A call list.
Tom Nguyen	Director, Wealth Planning	Where plan adoption is weak and how large the opportunity is.
Sofia Mendes	Head of Partner Referrals	Whether referral growth is turning into business.

What you need

- Power BI Desktop. The steps were written for the September 2026 release. Where an earlier release differs, a note says so.
- **Ridgemere_Starter.pbix** and **Ridgemere_Theme.json**, supplied by your instructor.
- For Lab 3 part E, access to a Power BI workspace you normally publish to. If you cannot publish today, you can still complete the part by following the instructor's demonstration.
- The Participant Workbook, for the sketches and worksheets.

How to read the steps

- **Bold** marks something you select or see on screen, written the way Power BI writes it.
- `style` marks a field or measure name, such as `Revenue Variance %`.
- A **Checkpoint** box tells you what you should see. If your screen differs, stop and ask.
- An **Adapt it** tip shows how to try the same idea on one of your own reports later. The labs are guided, not rigid: if you finish early, use the stretch goals.

Note: About the numbers

Cards usually show compact values such as \$205.19M or \$23.77bn. Rounding and units can vary slightly with your release and settings, so each checkpoint also gives the exact value. If the exact value matches, you are fine.

Set up (2 minutes)

Your instructor will ask you to do this just before the morning break, so that any problem with your machine can be sorted out before the first lab.

1. Open **Ridgemere_Starter.pbix** in Power BI Desktop.
2. Select **File > Save as** and save your own copy, for example **Ridgemere_YourName.pbix**. Work in the copy all day.
3. Check that you are in Report view and that you can see the **Filters**, **Visualizations**, and **Data** panes on the right.

If it goes wrong: The Visualizations pane is missing

Your Power BI Desktop is using the on-object interaction layout, which is a preview feature. These labs use the standard layout. Select **File > Options and settings > Options > Preview features**, clear **On-object interaction**, and restart Power BI Desktop.

A quick tour of the starter file

The file opens on **Performance (Before)**. That is the page you critiqued this morning. Leave it as it is: it is your "before".

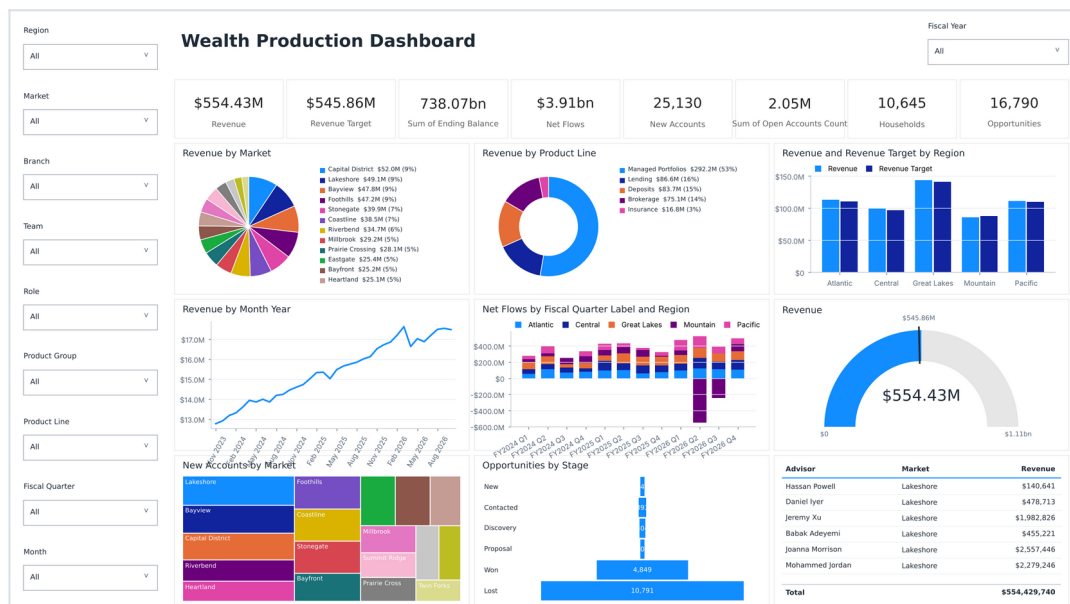


Figure 2. Illustration of Performance (Before), the page from the opening critique

Page	Purpose today
Performance (Before)	The crowded page from the opening critique. Your "before".
Visual Challenge	Six visuals that are a poor fit for their question. Lab 1.
Referral Summary	A draft summary page for referrals. Follow-along and Lab 2.
Opportunity Detail	A detail page that is not yet connected to anything. Lab 2.
Visual Lab	One question, several visuals. Lab 3 part B.
Market Detail	A diagnostic page that is not yet connected to anything. Lab 3 part C.
Household Detail	A record-level page. Lab 3 part C, stretch goal.

The data model is already built, and every measure you need exists. You will not write DAX today.

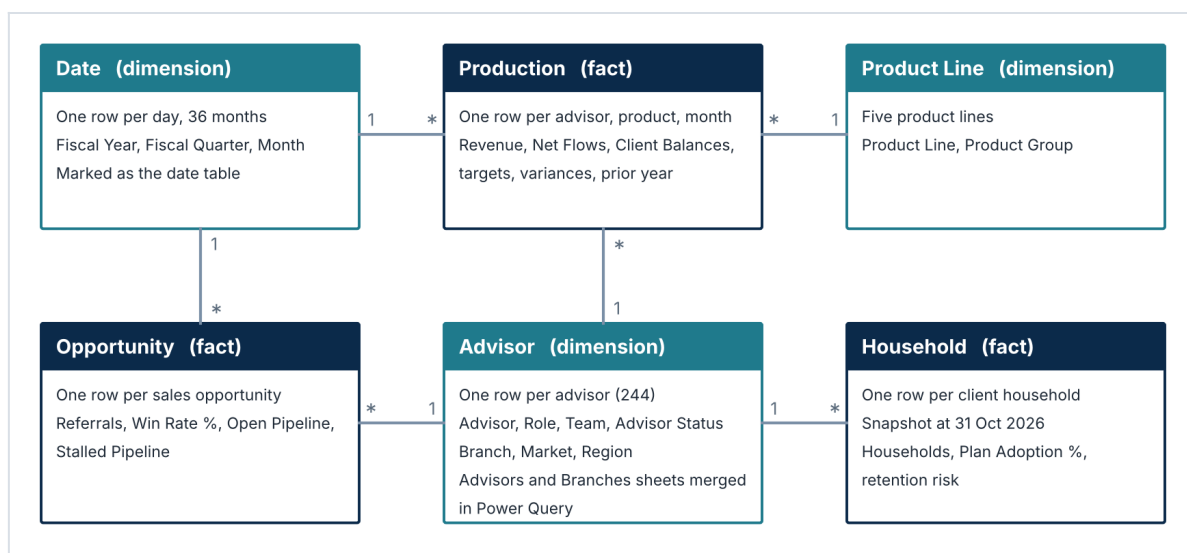


Figure 3. The semantic model behind every page

In the **Data** pane, measures sit inside folders in three tables. Most of today's measures are in the **Production** table, in the folders **Revenue**, **Net flows**, **Balances**, **Accounts**, and **Titles and colors**. Hover over any measure to read its description.

Lab 1: Visual-selection challenge and page redesign

Timing: 25 minutes, Module 2, slide 32

Part A, choose a better visual: 10 minutes. Part B, sketch a cleaner page: 8 minutes. Part C, start the build: 5 minutes. One table shares its sketch: 2 minutes.

Why this lab: the question picks the visual. Each visual on the **Visual Challenge** page answers a real business question badly. Your job is to pick the visual that answers it well.

Part A: Choose a better visual (10 minutes)

Go to the **Visual Challenge** page. Fix **at least four** of the six visuals. Do them in any order.

Tip: How to change a visual's type

Select the visual, then select a different icon in the **Visualizations** pane (**Build visual** tab). Power BI moves the fields to the new visual's field wells for you. It does not always put them where you want them, so check the wells every time.

Visual 1: How has revenue tracked against target through the year?

The table shows exact values, but the question is about a trend.

1. Select the table.
2. In the **Visualizations** pane, select **Line chart**.
3. Check the wells: **Month** on the **X-axis**; **Revenue** and **Revenue Target** on the **Y-axis**. Drag a field if it landed in the wrong well.
4. If the months are not in fiscal order (Nov to Oct), select **More options (...)** on the visual > **Sort axis** > **Month**, then **More options (...)** > **Sort axis** > **Sort ascending**.

Checkpoint

Two lines that cross between March and April. Revenue is above target from November to March and below it for most of the months after.

Visual 2: Which markets are furthest behind their revenue target?

A pie with 18 slices cannot rank anything, and it shows revenue when the question is about distance from target.

1. Select the pie chart, then select **Clustered bar chart**.
2. **Market** should now be on the **Y-axis**. Drag **Revenue Variance %** (Production table, Revenue folder) to the **X-axis** well and remove **Revenue** from it.
3. Sort it: **More options (...)** > **Sort axis** > **Revenue Variance %**, then **More options (...)** > **Sort axis** > **Sort ascending**.

4. Color the exceptions. Select the **Format visual** icon, then the **Visual** tab. Expand **Bars**, and next to **Color** select **fx**.
5. In the dialog, set **Format style** to **Field value**. Under **What field should we base this on?** choose **Revenue Variance Color** (Production table, Titles and colors folder). Select **OK**.

Checkpoint

Foothills is at the top at about -22.3%, in red. The other 17 markets are all ahead of target, between 0.4% and 8.3%, in a quiet slate color.

Visual 3: How did each product line contribute to the revenue variance?

Two tall columns per product line hide the small differences that the question is about.

1. Select the column chart, then select **Waterfall chart**.
2. Set the wells: **Product Line** in **Category**; **Revenue Variance** in **Y-axis**. Remove **Revenue** and **Revenue Target**.

Checkpoint

Three product lines add to the variance and two subtract: Managed Portfolios +\$1.40M, Brokerage - \$1.57M, Deposits +\$1.28M, Lending +\$1.41M, Insurance -\$0.07M. Total +\$2.44M. Brokerage is the one pulling the total down, and the column chart hid it.

Visual 4: Do advisors with higher plan adoption attract more net new money?

A bar for every advisor is a list, not a relationship.

1. Select the bar chart, then select **Scatter chart**.
2. Set the wells: **Advisor** in **Values**; **Plan Adoption %** on the **X Axis**; **Organic Net Flow Rate %** on the **Y Axis**.
3. Optional: add **Planning Designation** (Advisor table) to **Legend**.

Checkpoint

A cloud of more than 200 points that rises from lower left to upper right. Advisors with higher plan adoption tend to have a higher organic net flow rate. With the legend added, advisors who hold a planning designation sit higher and further right on average.

Visual 5: Where is plan adoption weakest, by market and asset band?

Stacking percentages produces totals of well over 200%. They mean nothing.

1. Select the stacked column chart, then select **Matrix**.
2. Set the wells: **Market** in **Rows**; **Asset Band** in **Columns**; **Plan Adoption %** in **Values**.

3. Add emphasis. In the **Values** well, select the down arrow next to **Plan Adoption %** > **Conditional formatting** > **Background color**.
4. Set **Format style** to **Gradient**. Choose a light red for the lowest value and a light green for the highest value. Select **OK**.

Checkpoint

In the **\$1M to \$5M** column, three markets stand out: Coastline 30%, Stonegate 36%, and Twin Forks 45%. The firm figure for that band is 64%.

Visual 6: What share of client balances sits in each product line?

Look carefully before you change this one. Write your decision, and your reason, in the workbook.

Ask

Is a donut a poor choice here? What would have to be different about the data for your answer to change?

Part B: Sketch a cleaner executive summary (8 minutes, in pairs)

Go back to **Performance (Before)**. Catherine Bouchard asked for "revenue, balances, accounts, and new openings for FY2026". She will open the page on a tablet and give it about five seconds.

Use the sketch grid in the Participant Workbook (Lab 1 sketch page). Design the page she should have received. Keep to these limits:

- One headline sentence at the top. Leave blanks for the numbers.
- No more than four numbers, each with its target or its change.
- No more than three charts. Say what question each one answers.
- No more than one slicer. Everything else goes to the Filters pane or disappears.
- A note that says where the detail lives and how a reader gets there.

Tip

Sketch boxes and labels, not artwork. If you cannot write the headline sentence, the page is not ready to design.

Part C: Start the build (5 minutes)

You will finish this page in Lab 3. For now, create it and add the headline numbers.

1. Select the **+** icon next to the page tabs to add a page.
2. Right-click the new page tab, select **Rename Page**, and name it **Executive Summary**. Drag the tab to the first position.
3. With nothing selected on the canvas, drag **Fiscal Year** (Date table) from the **Data** pane into the **Filters** pane, under **Filters on this page**. Select **FY2026**.

4. In the **Visualizations** pane, select **Card**. Add these measures from the Production table to the **Values** well, in this order: Revenue, Client Balances, Net Flows, New Accounts.
5. Drag the card to the top of the page and stretch it across the full width.
6. Save.

Checkpoint

Four numbers in one visual: Revenue \$205.19M (exact \$205,193,704), Client Balances \$23.77bn (\$23,774,280,332), Net Flows \$1.09bn (\$1,087,258,550), New Accounts 9,600.

If it goes wrong: I see fewer than four numbers

Make the card wider. If a value is still missing, check the **Values** well has all four measures. The card's layout settings are under **Format visual** > **Visual** tab; the section names for the card layout have changed between releases, so ask your instructor if you cannot find them.

Tip: Adapt it

On one of your own reports, pick the page with the most visuals. For each visual, write the question it answers. Any visual whose question you cannot write is a candidate for removal.

Follow-along: Edit interactions

Timing: 5 minutes, Module 3, slide 36

Follow the instructor. The aim is to see filter, highlight, and none side by side.

Go to the **Referral Summary** page.

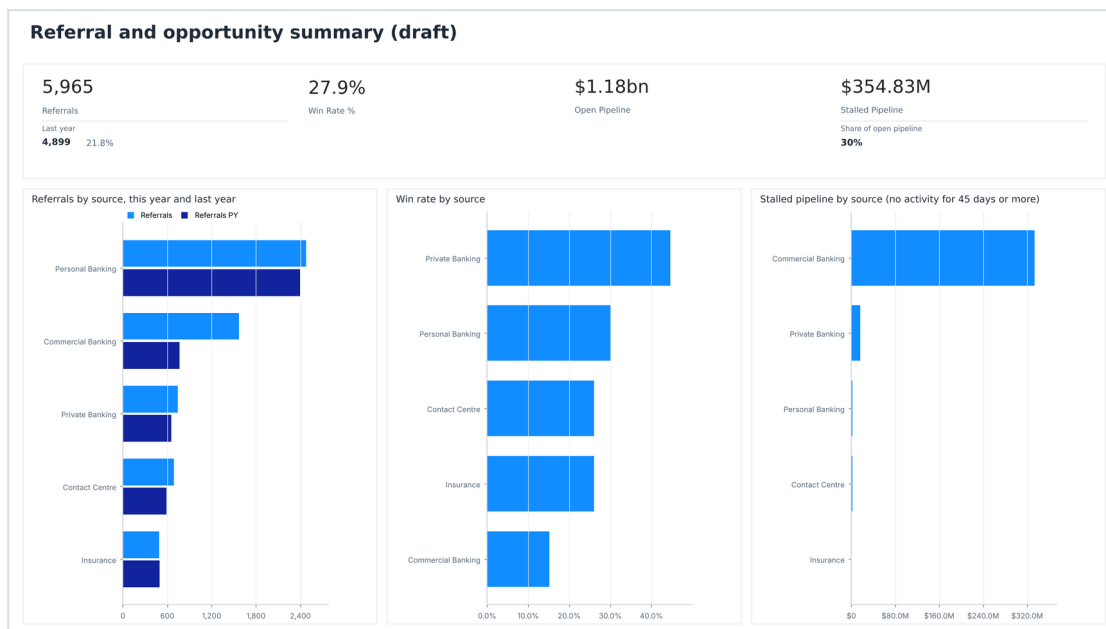


Figure 4. Illustration of the Referral Summary page in the starter file

1. Select the **Commercial Banking** bar in the chart **Referrals by source, this year and last year**. Watch the other visuals. The two bar charts dim everything except Commercial Banking; that is cross-highlighting. The card recalculates for Commercial Banking only; that is cross-filtering. Select the bar again to clear the selection.
2. Keep that chart selected. On the **Format** ribbon, select **Edit interactions**. Small icons appear on each of the other visuals.
3. On the **card**, select the **None** icon. The headline numbers will now ignore selections in this chart.
4. On **Win rate by source**, select the **Filter** icon and look at the result. Then select the **Highlight** icon and compare.
5. On the **Format** ribbon, select **Edit interactions** again to leave the mode.
6. Test it: select **Commercial Banking** once more. The card keeps showing the page totals.

Checkpoint

With Commercial Banking selected, the card still shows Referrals 5,965 and Stalled Pipeline \$354.83M. Before step 3 it changed to the Commercial Banking figures.

Note

Line charts, scatter charts, and maps can only be filtered. They cannot be highlighted. You set interactions one source visual at a time, and the setting is saved with the report for every reader.

Lab 2: Design a two-level referral journey

Timing: 15 minutes, Module 3, slide 47, in pairs

Step 1, read the summary: 3 minutes. Step 2, map the journey: 5 minutes. Step 3, wire it: 5 minutes. Step 4, one pair walks its path aloud: 2 minutes.

Why this lab: Sofia Mendes, Head of Partner Referrals, has heard that referrals are "up a lot". She needs to know whether the growth is turning into business, and who should act. A summary page alone cannot answer that. A path from summary to detail can.

Step 1: Read the summary (3 minutes)

On **Referral Summary**, answer these questions with your partner. Write the answers in the workbook (Lab 2 page).

1. How much did referrals grow, and what happened to the win rate?
2. Which source grew the most? What is its win rate?
3. Where is the stalled pipeline? (Stalled means an open opportunity with no activity for 45 days or more.)

Step 2: Map the journey (5 minutes)

Before you touch Power BI, complete the journey template in the workbook:

- **Level 1, summary:** the headline Sofia should read first, as one sentence.
- **Launch point:** the visual and the data point a user will right-click.
- **Drillthrough field:** the field that carries the user's choice to the next page.
- **Level 2, detail:** what the user sees on arrival, and what tells them where they are.
- **Action:** who does what after reading the detail page.

Step 3: Wire it with drillthrough (5 minutes)

1. Go to the **Opportunity Detail** page. Select an empty part of the canvas so that no visual is selected.
2. In the **Visualizations** pane (**Build visual** tab), scroll down to the **Drillthrough** section.
3. From the **Data** pane, drag Source L0B (Opportunity table) into the **Drillthrough filters** well. The well may be labeled "Add drillthrough fields here".
4. Look at the top left of the page. Power BI has added a **Back** button. If it overlaps the page heading, drag one of them aside.
5. Go back to **Referral Summary**. In the chart **Stalled pipeline by source**, right-click the **Commercial Banking** bar, select **Drill through**, then **Opportunity Detail**.

Checkpoint

You arrive on Opportunity Detail, filtered to Commercial Banking: 520 open opportunities, Open Pipeline \$795.12M, 198 stalled opportunities, Stalled Pipeline \$333.72M. The chart of stalled pipeline by market is led by Capital District, Bayview, and Heartland. The table lists the opportunities, largest first, with the advisor, days since activity, and next step.

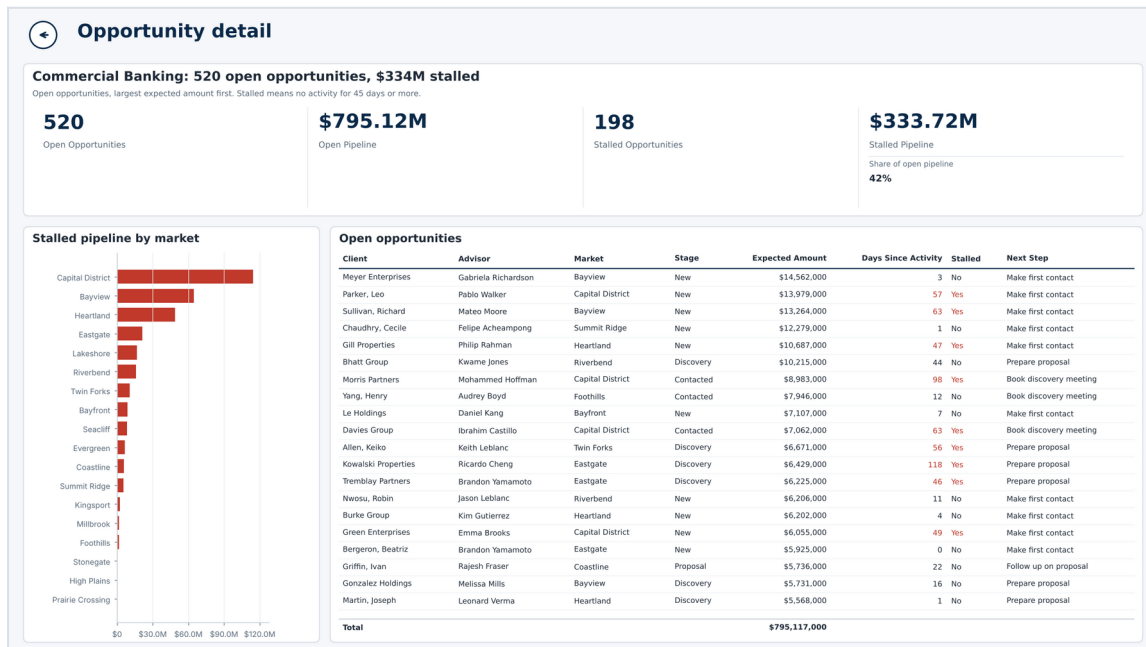


Figure 5. Illustration of the arrival on Opportunity Detail. Your page keeps the default look until you apply the theme in Lab 3.

- Return to the summary: hold **Ctrl** and select the **Back** button. In Power BI Desktop, buttons need Ctrl + click. Your readers in the Power BI service will use a single click.

If it goes wrong: Drill through is not in the right-click menu

The field in the **Drillthrough filters** well must also be in the visual you right-click. Check that you right-clicked a bar in a chart that uses Source LOB, and that Source LOB is the field in the well on Opportunity Detail.

Step 4: Walk the path aloud (2 minutes)

One pair narrates its journey as Sofia would experience it: "I open the report and read... I notice... I right-click... I arrive on... Now I know who should act: ..."

Tip: Adapt it

Think of a report of yours with a long table at the bottom of a summary page. Would that table work better as a drillthrough page that arrives already filtered to what the reader chose?

Lab 3: Guided build and refinement

Timing: 75 minutes, Module 4, slides 48 to 58

Set up 5. Part A, build the executive view: 25. Part B, one question, several visuals: 10. Part C, drillthrough: 12. Part D, tune interactions, slicers, and theme: 8. Part E, publish and validate: 7. Part F, trust check: 5. Before and after: 3.

Your instructor demonstrates each part first. Then you build it. This is the page you are aiming for:

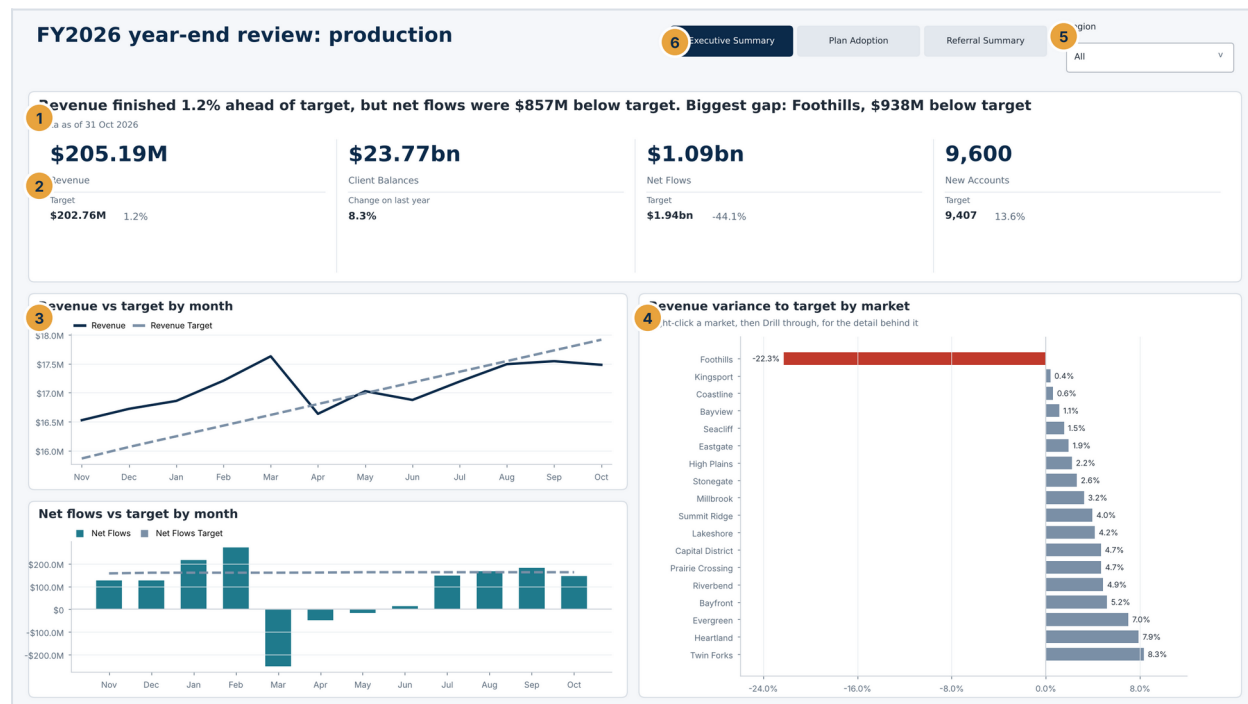


Figure 6. Illustration of the finished Executive Summary. Yours will look similar once the theme is applied in part D.

Element	The job it does	
1	Headline sentence	States the insight. It is a title driven by a measure, so it stays true when the data or the filters change.
2	Card with reference labels	Four numbers, each with its target or its change.
3	Trend with target	Shows when the result moved away from target.
4	Segment view with flags	Shows where the variance is concentrated. The launch point for drillthrough.
5	One slicer	The only control that changes a decision on this page.
6	Page navigation	Tells the reader what else exists. The instructor will show this one.

Set up (5 minutes)

1. Open your copy of the starter file.
2. Go to your **Executive Summary** page. If you did not create it in Lab 1 part C, do steps 1 to 6 of that part now.
3. Keep your Lab 1 sketch beside you. You are about to build it.

Part A: Build the executive view (25 minutes)

A1. Add target and variance to the headline numbers

A number without context invites the question "is that good?". Reference labels answer it inside the card.

1. Select the card. In the **Visualizations** pane, select the **Format visual** icon.
2. On the **Visual** tab, expand **Reference labels**.
3. In **Apply settings to**, select Revenue.
4. Drag Revenue Target from the **Data** pane to the **Add label** field. Then select Revenue Target in the **Add label** dropdown.
5. Expand **Detail** and turn it **On**. Drag Revenue Variance % to the **Details** field.
6. Repeat steps 3 to 5 for Net Flows: add Net Flows Target as the label and Net Flows Variance % as the detail.

Checkpoint

Revenue \$205.19M, with Revenue Target \$202.76M and 1.2%. Net Flows \$1.09bn, with Net Flows Target \$1.94bn and -44.1%. One of these is good news. One is not.

A2. Add the trend with its target

1. Select an empty part of the canvas. In the **Visualizations** pane, select **Line chart**.
2. Add Month (Date table) to the **X-axis**. Add Revenue and Revenue Target to the **Y-axis**.
3. Place the chart under the card, on the left half of the page.
4. Give it a plain title. Select **Format visual**, then the **General** tab. Expand **Title** and type Revenue vs target by month in **Text**.

Checkpoint

Revenue starts above target in November (\$16.53M against \$15.87M) and finishes below it in October (\$17.48M against \$17.91M). The lines cross between March and April.

A3. Add the segment view that flags where to look

1. Select an empty part of the canvas. Select **Clustered bar chart**.
2. Add Market (Advisor table) to the **Y-axis** and Revenue Variance % to the **X-axis**.
3. Sort it: **More options (...)** > **Sort axis** > **Revenue Variance %**, then **More options (...)** > **Sort axis** > **Sort ascending**.

4. Flag the exceptions with color: **Format visual** > **Visual** tab > **Bars** > next to **Color** select **fx**. Set **Format style** to **Field value**, choose **Revenue Variance Color**, and select **OK**.
5. On the same **Visual** tab, turn **Data labels** **On**.
6. Title it **Revenue variance to target by market**, and place it under the card, on the right half of the page.

Checkpoint

Eighteen bars. Foothills is first at -22.3%, in red. Kingsport is next at 0.4%. Twin Forks is last at 8.3%. Only one bar is not slate.

A4. Let the page state its own headline

1. Select the card. Select **Format visual**, then the **General** tab.
2. Turn **Title On** and expand it. Next to the title **Text**, select **fx**.
3. In the dialog, choose the measure **Exec Headline** (Production table, Titles and colors folder). Select **OK**.
4. Still under **Title**, increase the font size to 14 so that the sentence is the first thing a reader sees.

Checkpoint

The card's title reads: **Revenue finished 1.2% ahead of target, but net flows were \$857M below target. Biggest gap: Foothills, \$938M below target**

Wow moment

Nobody typed that sentence. The measure wrote it from the data, and it will rewrite itself when the numbers or the filters change. You will see that in part D.

A5. Refactor for hierarchy (slide 52)

Spend the remaining minutes on the three things slide 52 names: stronger titles, consistent spacing and alignment, and emphasis on the primary signal.

1. Make the card the widest and highest element on the page. The headline belongs where the eye lands first, at the top left.
2. Align the two charts: hold **Ctrl** and select both, then on the **Format** ribbon select **Align** > **Align top**. Make them the same height.
3. Leave the same gap between all three visuals and the same margin around the page edge.
4. Read each title aloud. A title should say what the visual shows in plain words. Change any that still read like field lists.

Checkpoint

Compare your page with your Lab 1 sketch and with the illustration at the start of this lab. Headline first, four numbers with context, one trend, one view by market that flags a single exception.

Stretch goals for part A

- Add a subtitle that says how current the data is: select the card > **Format visual** > **General** tab > **Title** > turn **Subtitle On** > select **fx** next to the subtitle text > choose **Data As Of**.
- Add a second trend under the first: a **Line and clustered column chart** with **Month** on the **X-axis**, **Net Flows** on the **Column y-axis**, and **Net Flows Target** on the **Line y-axis**. Which months had net outflows?
- Add reference labels for **Client Balances** (label **Balance Growth %**) and **New Accounts** (label **New Accounts Target**).
- Add alt text to the market chart: select it > **Format visual** > **General** tab > **Alt text**. Write what the visual shows, not what it is.
- Set the tab order so that a keyboard user meets the headline first: on the **View** tab, under **Show panes**, select **Selection**, then **Tab order**.

Tip: Adapt it

On one of your own summary pages, write the headline sentence first. Then look at each visual on the page: does it support that sentence, explain it, or distract from it?

Part B: One question, several visuals (10 minutes)

Go to the **Visual Lab** page. Every visual on this page will answer the same question: **are we on our revenue target?**

1. Read the two visuals that are already there: the card and the table. What does each one tell you?
2. Add a line chart: select an empty part of the canvas > **Line chart** > **Month** on the **X-axis**; **Revenue** and **Revenue Target** on the **Y-axis**. Check that the months run from Nov to Oct. If they do not, sort by **Month** ascending (**More options (...)** > **Sort axis**).
3. Make a KPI visual from a copy of the line chart: select the line chart, press **Ctrl + C** then **Ctrl + V**, and move the copy to an empty area. With the copy selected, select **KPI** in the **Visualizations** pane. Check the wells: **Revenue** in **Value**; **Month** in **Trend axis**; **Revenue Target** in **Target**.
4. Add a gauge: select an empty part of the canvas > **Gauge** > **Revenue** in **Value**; **Revenue Target** in **Target value**.

Note: Why copy the line chart to make the KPI?

A KPI visual has no sort option. It reports the last point on its trend axis, so the months must be in the right order before you convert. This is the method Microsoft Learn describes.

Checkpoint

- **Card:** \$205.19M against a target of \$202.76M. 1.2% ahead.
- **KPI:** \$17.48M against a goal of \$17.91M. 2.42% behind, shown in red. It is reporting October, the latest month.
- **Gauge:** the fill stops at about the halfway mark, and the scale runs from \$0 to \$410.39M. By default, a gauge sets its maximum to twice the value.
- **Line chart:** ahead until March, behind in most months since.

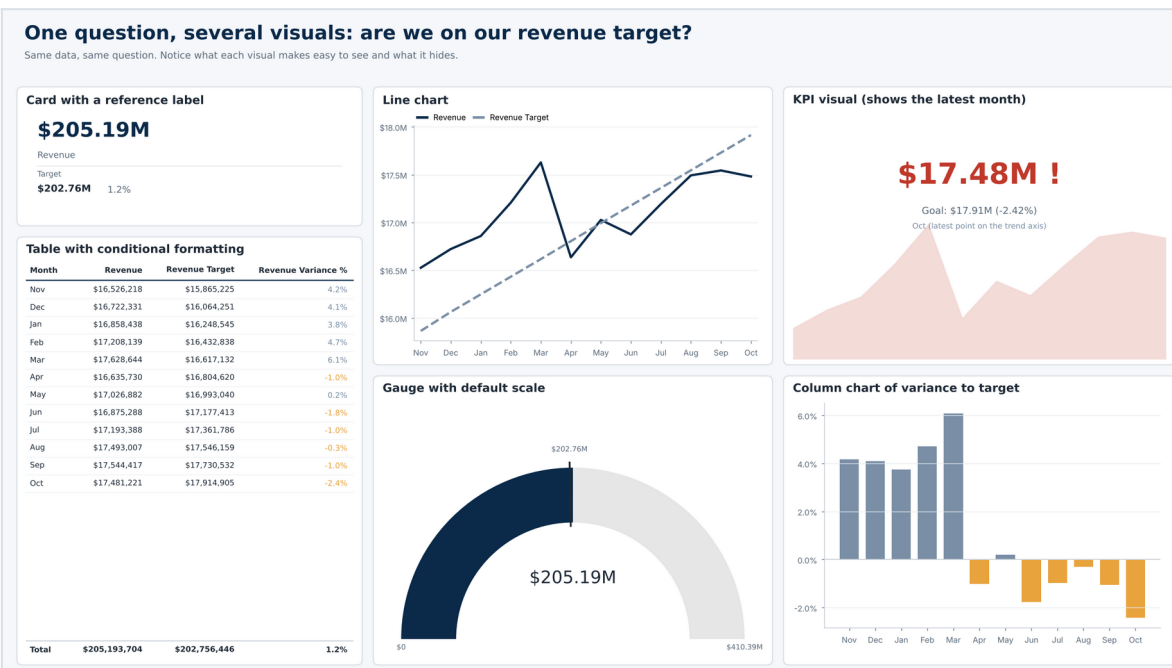


Figure 7. Illustration: one question, several visuals. This version adds a column chart of the monthly variance.

Now complete the comparison table in the workbook (Lab 3 part B page), then discuss with your neighbor:

Ask

The card says we are ahead. The KPI says we are behind. Which one is right? Which would you put in front of Catherine, and what would you add so that she is not misled?

Tip: Adapt it

Take one question your stakeholders ask often. Build three standard visuals that answer it, side by side, and ask a colleague which one they understood fastest.

Part C: Drillthrough from summary to detail (12 minutes)

Catherine has her number. Daniel Okafor, who runs the Mountain region, now has a question: why Foothills? The **Market Detail** page can answer it, but nothing leads to it yet. Follow the four steps on slide 54.

C1. Create: use the prepared detail page

Go to **Market Detail**. The visuals are already built so that you can spend your time on the journey. Notice what the page contains: headline numbers, two monthly charts, and a table of advisors.

C2. Add the field

1. Select an empty part of the canvas so that no visual is selected.
2. In the **Visualizations** pane, scroll to the **Drillthrough** section. Drag **Market** (Advisor table) into the **Drillthrough filters** well.
3. Power BI adds a **Back** button to the page, normally at the top left. If it overlaps the page heading, drag one of them aside.

C3. Add context for arrival

A reader who lands here must know at once where they are and what they are looking at.

1. Select the card on Market Detail. Select **Format visual** > **General** tab > turn **Title On** > select **fx** next to the title text > choose **Market Detail Title** > **OK**.
2. Open the **Filters** pane and confirm the page still has **Fiscal Year is FY2026** under **Filters on this page**. That is the key filter a reader needs on arrival.
3. Right-click the **Market Detail** page tab and select **Hide**. Readers will reach this page by drillthrough, not from the page list.

C4. Test from the summary

1. Go to **Executive Summary**. In the market chart, right-click the **Foothills** bar, select **Drill through**, then **Market Detail**.

Checkpoint

The title reads: **Foothills: revenue 22.3% behind target; net flows -\$770M vs target \$169M**

The card shows Revenue \$14.80M (exact \$14,796,274), Net Flows -\$769.61M, Client Balances \$1.33bn, Households Lost 98, High Risk Households 51.

The revenue line leaves its target after February. Net flows are sharply negative from March to June. At the top of the advisor table are three Private Wealth Advisors with the status Departed: Vikram Kumar, Arjun Salazar, and Amir Jensen. Each has zero balances and between 27 and 32 households lost.

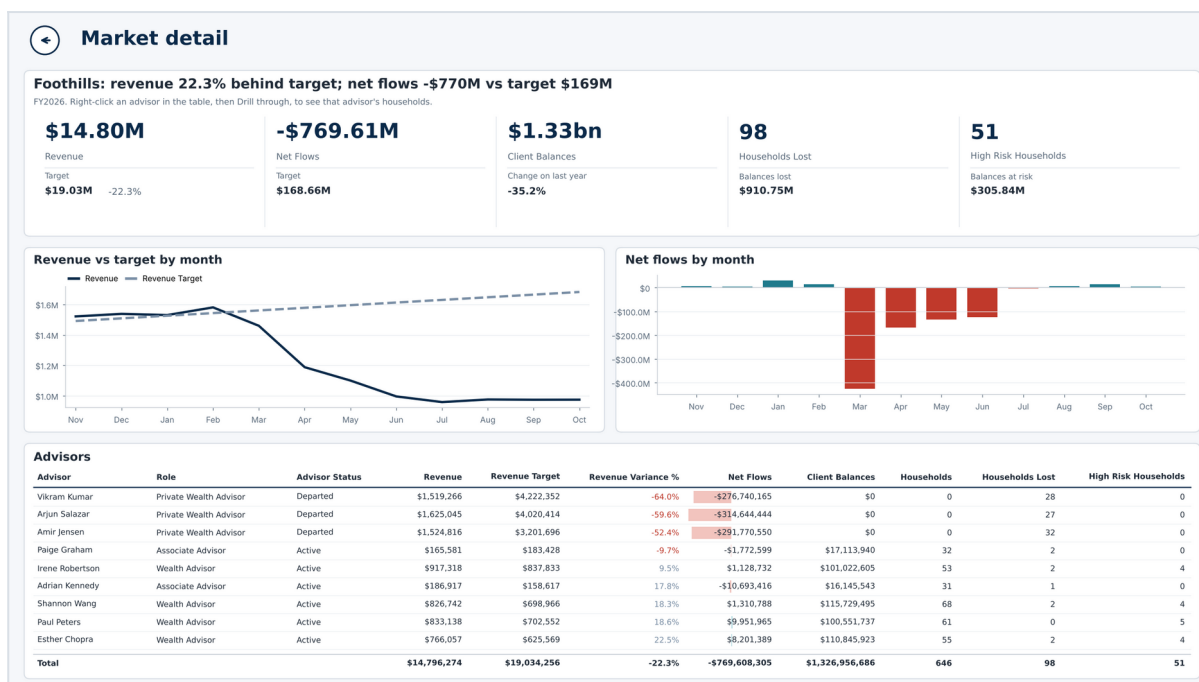


Figure 8. Illustration of Market Detail after drilling through from Foothills

2. Hold **Ctrl** and select the **Back** button to return to the summary.

Wow moment

In two clicks you went from "revenue is on target" to the reason one market is not: three senior advisors left at the end of February, and 98 households with \$910.75M of balances followed them.

Tip: Adapt it

Pick a report of yours where a detail table sits under a summary. Move the table to its own page, add the field your readers would choose as the drillthrough field, and give the page a title that names what they chose.

Stretch goal for part C: the third level

Priya Raman, the Foothills market leader, needs to know what to do on Monday.

1. On **Household Detail**, drag **Advisor** (Advisor table) into the **Drillthrough filters** well. Set the card's title to the measure **Household Detail Title**, and hide the page.
2. On **Market Detail** (drill through from Foothills again), right-click **Louis Patel** in the advisor table > **Drill through** > **Household Detail**.

Checkpoint

Louis Patel: 69 households, 8 at high retention risk (\$71.7M). The table lists his households with the highest risk first. Every high-risk household has a previous advisor who left. Days Since Contact shows who to call first.

Part D: Tune interactions, slicers, and theme (8 minutes)

D1. Make interactions intentional

Selecting a market should explore the trend. It should not rewrite the firm's headline.

1. On **Executive Summary**, select the market bar chart. On the **Format** ribbon, select **Edit interactions**.
2. On the **card**, select **None**. Leave the line chart on **Filter**.
3. Select **Edit interactions** again to leave the mode.
4. Test it: select the **Foothills** bar. The trend now shows Foothills alone, and its revenue falls away from target after February. The headline does not change. Select the bar again to clear it.

D2. Apply the slicer decision test

The crowded page has ten slicers. Your page should expose only a control that changes a decision.

1. Select an empty part of the canvas. Select **Slicer** in the **Visualizations** pane and add **Region** (Advisor table). Place it at the top right.
2. Choose **Mountain** in the slicer and read your headline again.

Checkpoint

With Mountain selected, the headline rewrites itself: **Revenue finished 11.4% behind target and net flows were \$947M below target. Biggest gap: Foothills, \$938M below target.** With Pacific it reads: **Revenue finished 2.3% ahead of target and net flows were \$71M above target.** Clear the slicer when you have seen it.

3. Open the **Filters** pane. Your **Fiscal Year** filter is there, visible to readers, without taking space on the page. If readers should not change it, select the **Lock filter** icon on the filter card.

Note: The difference between the two

A slicer changes the scope of the whole page, including the headline, because that is the reader's deliberate choice. A click on a bar is exploration, so the headline stays put. Both behaviors are design decisions that you made on purpose.

D3. Apply the theme

1. On the **Design** ribbon, select **Import theme**. Choose **Ridgemere_Theme.json** and confirm. A dialog tells you the import succeeded.
2. Look at every page. Colors, fonts, backgrounds, and borders changed everywhere at once.

Note: If you do not have a Design ribbon

The Design ribbon arrived in the September 2026 release. In the August 2026 release, go to the **View** ribbon, turn on the **Theme** pane, expand **Theme settings**, and select **Import theme**. In earlier releases, go to the **View** ribbon, open the **Themes** dropdown, and select **Browse for themes**.

Checkpoint

Charts are now navy and teal on a pale canvas. Your market chart is still red and slate: formatting that you apply to a visual wins over the theme, and the colors come from a measure.

3. Look, but do not select: on the **Design** ribbon, select **Customize theme**. Under **Theme settings** you can see the **Base theme** of this report. If Power BI offers **Update theme**, leave it alone for now. Your instructor will explain why: on a real report, check your custom theme against the new base theme first.

Tip: Adapt it

On one of your own pages, select the visual that readers click most often and turn on **Edit interactions**. Look at each icon. Did you choose those behaviors, or did you inherit the defaults?

Part E: Publish and validate (7 minutes)

A report is finished when it works for the reader, not when it looks right on your canvas.

1. Go to **Executive Summary** so that it is the page the report opens on. Save the file.
2. On the **Home** ribbon, select **Publish**. Choose the workspace your instructor names (or your own workspace), then select **Select**. If your organization requires a sensitivity label, apply it the way you normally do.
3. When publishing finishes, select the link to open the report in the Power BI service.
4. Check the report the way a reader meets it:
 - ☐ The report opens on Executive Summary, and the headline is the first thing I read.
 - ☐ Hidden pages (Market Detail, and Household Detail if you hid it) are not in the page list.
 - ☐ Right-click **Foothills** > **Drill through** > **Market Detail** works, and the title names Foothills.
 - ☐ The **Back** button works with a single click.
 - ☐ The **Filters** pane shows Fiscal Year is FY2026.
 - ☐ Selecting a market changes the trend and leaves the headline alone.
 - ☐ The Region slicer changes the headline.

Note: If you cannot publish today

Watch the instructor's demonstration, then run the same checklist in Power BI Desktop. Remember that buttons need Ctrl + click there.

Tip: Adapt it

Open one of your published reports in the Power BI service, as a reader would, with this checklist beside you.

Part F: Trust check (5 minutes, in pairs)

Swap seats or screens with a partner. Run the three checks on slide 57 against your partner's report, and note what you find in the workbook (Lab 3 part F page).

Check	Try this
Is the message accurate?	Does the headline sentence agree with the numbers on the card? Drill through from Foothills: does the title on Market Detail (22.3% behind target) agree with the Foothills bar on the summary? Does the table total for Revenue (\$14,796,274) agree with the card on the same page?
Is the context sufficient?	Can you tell which period you are looking at? Does every headline number have a target or a comparison? Is anything on the page a number you could misread?
Can the user trace from summary to supporting detail?	Start at the headline. Can you reach the advisors behind it, and get back, without getting lost?

Now run the same three checks on **Performance (Before)**.

Ask

One card on that page is wrong by a factor of about thirty. Which one, and why? One more is wrong for the same reason. And what period do the cards on that page cover?

Tip: Adapt it

Run the three checks on a report of your own before its next release. Better still, ask a colleague to run them: they will see what you no longer notice.

Before and after (3 minutes)

Put **Performance (Before)** and your **Executive Summary** side by side in your mind, and complete the last line of the workbook page: "The most important change I made was ... because ...". One or two people will share.

Before	After
28 visuals, equal weight	A headline, four numbers with context, two or three charts
Ten slicers	One slicer, one visible filter
Default charts and titles	Visuals chosen by question; titles in plain words
No period, no targets	Period stated; target and variance beside each number
No path to detail	Summary, diagnostic page, record-level page, and a way back
Reader works out the meaning	The page states it

Reference

Measures you used today

Measure	Meaning
Revenue, Revenue Target	Revenue earned in the period, and its target. Targets are set at the start of each fiscal year.
Revenue Variance, Revenue Variance %	Revenue less target, in dollars and as a share of target. Negative means behind target.
Client Balances	Balances at the end of the selected period. A snapshot: it reports the latest month and never adds months together.
Balance Growth %	Change in client balances on one year earlier. Includes market movement as well as net flows.
Net Flows, Net Flows Target, Net Flows Variance %	Net new client money (inflows less outflows, excluding market movement), its target, and the variance.
New Accounts, New Accounts Target	Accounts opened in the period, and the target.
Households, Households Lost, Lost Balances	Active households at 31 October 2026; households that closed during FY2026; the balances they held a year earlier.
High Risk Households, High Risk Balances	Active households flagged with high retention risk, and their balances.
Plan Adoption %	Share of active households with an active wealth plan.
Organic Net Flow Rate %	FY2026 net flows from households that were already clients at the start of the year, as a share of their opening balances.
Referrals, Win Rate %	Opportunities referred by another line of business; won opportunities as a share of closed ones.
Open Pipeline, Stalled Pipeline	Expected balances of open opportunities; of open opportunities with no activity for 45 days or more.
Exec Headline, Market Detail Title, Household Detail Title, Data As Of	Text measures for titles and subtitles.
Revenue Variance Color	Returns a color: red when revenue is more than 5% behind target, amber when behind, slate otherwise. Used for conditional formatting by field value.

Where things are in Power BI Desktop

To do this	Go here
Add or rename a page	+ next to the page tabs; right-click a tab > Rename Page
Hide a page	Right-click the page tab > Hide
Add a page filter	Drag a field to Filters on this page in the Filters pane
Change a visual's type	Select the visual, then select another icon in the Visualizations pane
Sort a visual	More options (...) > Sort axis
Add reference labels to a card	Format visual > Visual tab > Reference labels
Color bars by a measure	Format visual > Visual tab > Bars > Color > fx > Field value
Format cells in a table or matrix	Down arrow next to the field in the well > Conditional formatting
Bind a title to a measure	Format visual > General tab > Title > fx
Add alt text	Format visual > General tab > Alt text
Align visuals	Select them with Ctrl + click, then Format ribbon > Align
Control how visuals affect each other	Select a visual, then Format ribbon > Edit interactions
Make a page a drillthrough target	Drag a field to Drillthrough filters in the Visualizations pane
Follow a button in Desktop	Ctrl + click
Add a page navigator	Insert tab > Buttons > Navigator > Page navigator
Import a theme	Design ribbon > Import theme (September 2026 release)
Publish	Home ribbon > Publish

If something does not work

Symptom	What to check
A visual is blank after you changed its type	The field wells. A measure or a category is missing or in the wrong well.
Months appear in alphabetical order	Sort the visual by Month, ascending. The model sorts Month in fiscal order (Nov first).
Drill through is missing from the right-click menu	The drillthrough field must be in the visual you right-click, and not aggregated. Right-click a bar or a row, not empty space.
The Back button does nothing	In Power BI Desktop, hold Ctrl and select it.
The KPI shows the wrong month	The chart was not sorted by Month before you converted it. Delete the KPI, sort the line chart, and convert a fresh copy.
A number does not match a checkpoint	The page filter. Executive Summary, Visual Lab, and Market Detail need Fiscal Year is FY2026.
The conditional color did nothing	In the dialog, Format style must be Field value , and the field must be Revenue Variance Color.
The theme did not change one visual	You formatted that visual directly. Direct formatting wins over the theme until you reset the visual to default.

Optional readiness check for newer Power BI users

If you build reports less often, try these five things in the starter file before the course or during a break. Each takes a minute or two.

- ☐ Add a new page, add a column chart of Revenue by Region, then delete the page.
- ☐ Change that chart to a bar chart and sort it.
- ☐ Add a slicer for Fiscal Year and select FY2026.
- ☐ Find the **Format visual** icon and change a chart title.
- ☐ Find **Publish** on the **Home** ribbon (you do not need to publish).

If all five felt comfortable, you are ready for every lab in this guide.